

Knee Swelling - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1462 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- UAT-only adult and pediatric non-traumatic knee-swelling pathway screening for septic arthritis, systemic illness, vascular compromise and inability to bear weight before in-person assessment.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the swelling lasted?
2. [YES_NO] Is the skin red, hot, or painful to touch?
3. [YES_NO] Is the person able to bear weight normally?
4. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the age; is there systemic illness, recent infection/procedure, immune risk, pregnancy/postpartum status, calf swelling, hidden trauma or child safeguarding concern?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Motor Vehicle Accident

Did this problem begin with a motor vehicle crash or as part of a multi-system crash injury?

A motor vehicle crash or multi-system crash injury belongs in the Motor Vehicle Accident pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Is knee swelling severely painful with inability to bear weight or neurovascular change, or is it hot with marked systemic illness, confusion, breathing change, collapse or rapid deterioration?

NHS.UK joint pain guidance identifies these as reasons for urgent clinical review - a swollen, hot knee can indicate joint infection needing prompt treatment; the local Qatar urgent-care pathway is used here.

1. Disposition level 70

With no emergency feature, is there any persistent or unexplained knee swelling, redness/heat, walking limitation, calf symptoms, child concern or higher-risk context?

In-person examination is required to distinguish infection, inflammatory/crystal disease, vascular causes and occult trauma.

Advice

Qatar emergency knee-joint response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for hot swollen knee with systemic illness, severe pain, inability to bear weight, neurovascular change or rapid deterioration; do not self-drive. Do not force walking. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: fever worsens; unable to bear weight.

In-person knee-swelling assessment

- Arrange in-person assessment; telephone review cannot exclude joint infection, inflammatory disease, crystal arthritis, vascular causes or occult trauma. Medication and exact Qatar destination are local approval required.
- Call Back If: redness, warmth or fever; unable to bear weight.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for hot swollen knee with systemic illness, severe pain, inability to bear weight, neurovascular change or rapid deterioration; do not self-drive. Do not force walking. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Joint pain", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/joint-pain/> (page last reviewed 26 February 2026) - applied to knee swelling

Provenance

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